A WARRIOR AND THE WARLORDS

Aaiye, Ashfaq sahib (Welcome, Ashfaq sahib)/ said a deep voice in the shadows of a luxury suite at Hotel Marmara Taksim in the heart of Istanbul. As Ashfaq Khan entered, a six foot tall Pathan with a Kalashnikov pointed the barrel at his chest.

'Nahi, koizarurat nahi. Yeh dost hai (No need for that, he is a friend)/ said the voice with a tinge of scorn for the Pathan, a thirty-four-year-old from Mazar-e-Sharif.

Clearly, Khan was one of a rare group of people permitted to enter Room No. 209 without a body search.

'How are you, Mirza sahib?' Khan gave his host a warm hug. The bulky man who had welcomed Khan so affectionately was the legendary Afghan warlord Mirza Murad Rustam. Today, he occupies prominent position in the Afghanistan government.

Mirza patted Khan on the back. 'Achha hai, humko thoda bahut Hindi aata hai, aap logo se hi sikha hai, ghabraiye nahi (I'm very well. I

learned a little Hindi from your people, don't worry).'

R&AW agent Ashfaq Khan had been chasing the elusive general since the first week of June 1997, when Mirza was forced to flee Mazar-e-Sharif after a betrayal by his own lieutenant general, Abdul Malik Pahlawan. Once his confidant, Pahlawan had quietly sold Mirza and his citadel to the Taliban's Mullah Omar. The reason for the betrayal was personal. A relative of Pahlawan had been killed in suspicious circumstances and he believed that Mirza and his close aide Ismail Khan had been behind it.